temple. In one of his verses he addresses the deity as he might speak to a man of an upper caste: 'I am so hungry; I have come for your leavings, I am full of hope.' In another verse, he brings a 'bowl for your leftover food'; with no access to the shrine, he seeks to fulfil his devotion by serving the deity, submitting himself completely and eating the scraps left behind. This is alarmingly conformist, yet revealing of the extent to which Chokhamela's abject social condition had no bearing on his spiritual standing nor on the extent of his posthumous sanctification. Among the Lingayat saints, too, there were many of humble origins. While Basava, the founder of the sect, was born a Brahmin, many of his prominent disciples were of humbler origins: as Manu S. Pillai records, Allama Prabhu was a drummer, Siddharama a cowherd, Maccayya a washerman, and Kakkaya, a skinner of dead cows.[2]

Still, social mobility was relatively rare in Hinduism, and the lot of the outcastes was a terrible one. Was this because of the religion or the society that practised it? Arguably, Untouchability was a social practice for which it is impossible to find scriptural sanction. To suggest that to be a good Hindu you had to practise caste discrimination is therefore theologically unsound. As the philosopher Jonardon Ganeri has explained, 'Hinduism contains within itself the philosophical resources to sustain an internal critique of reprehensible and unjust social practices that have sometimes emerged in Hindu societies.' As those who are familiar with Adi Shankara's beliefs will testify, the Upanishadic insistence on the unity of being, a divinity available to everyone, the *atma* residing in everyone, and the idea that all human souls ultimately merge into the same Brahman, for instance, implies the equality of all souls and argues against caste discrimination. So does the Vedantic concept of the welfare of all human beings, irrespective of social or economic distinctions: '*bahujana sukhaya bahujana hitaya cha*'. Adi Shankara himself is said to have met an outcaste, Chandala, who was ordered by his disciples to move out of the path of the great sage. 'Who are you to ask me to move for you?' the outcaste asked the great *rishi*. 'Is the Self within me different from the Self within you?' Shankara was so struck by this enunciation of Advaita wisdom by the low-born Chandala